

JAPAN'S GREAT CASTLES

Kumamoto Castle

熊本城 | KUMAMOTO, JAPAN

Stone walls built to repel any army have outlasted cannon fire and two earthquakes a decade apart.

Kiyomasa built it, fire burned it, the ground shook it — twice — and still the walls stand.

A guide to the one castle in Japan where the repair work itself is part of the visit.

JAPAN'S GREAT CASTLES / BOOK ONE

Before you go

Admission fees, opening hours and public access at Kumamoto Castle are subject to change, and are unusually unsettled since the July 2026 earthquake. Always check the official website for the latest information before visiting.

Kumamoto Castle official site: <https://castle.kumamoto-guide.jp/>

Basic Data

At a glance

Name	Kumamoto Castle (Kumamoto-jo) — also known as Ginnan-jo, the Ginkgo Castle
Location	1-1 Honmaru, Chuo-ku, Kumamoto City, Kumamoto Prefecture
Type	Castle. National Historic Site, designated 1933
Important Cultural Properties	Uto Turret and 12 other turrets/gates (13 buildings), designated 1933
The keep	Main keep: six roofs, six floors over a basement. Secondary keep: four roofs, four floors over a basement. Rebuilt 1960 in reinforced concrete
Founded	1601 to around 1607, under Kato Kiyomasa
Present status	Damaged 2016; keep repairs completed 2021. Struck again by the Reiwa 8 Kumamoto Earthquake (M7.1) on 28 July 2026; reopened 13 August 2026
Official site	https://castle.kumamoto-guide.jp/

I How this book is arranged

- ▶ Chapter 1 — History: a castle built to never suffer siege again
- ▶ Chapter 2 — Reading the architecture: a castle that shows its scars
- ▶ Chapter 3 — Walking the castle: a route guide
- ▶ Chapter 4 — Visiting: hours, access, seasons and the neighbourhood

History — a castle built to never suffer siege again

| A castle-builder shaped by starvation

Kato Kiyomasa distinguished himself at Sekigahara and came away with the whole of Higo province. Before that, as one of Toyotomi Hideyoshi's trusted generals, he had fought in the invasions of Korea and endured the siege of Ulsan Castle — weeks of holding a fortress with no water and no food left. That experience, more than any other, decided what kind of castle he would build when he finally had one of his own.

Kiyomasa began work on the hill of Chausuyama in 1601 and had the castle substantially complete by around 1607. He was not building for looks. He was building **a castle that would never again be starved into surrender** — a fortress prepared, in earnest, for a siege that might last indefinitely. More than **120 wells** were dug across the grounds, and tradition holds that even the building materials were chosen with hunger in mind: dried gourd strips woven into the tatami facing, taro stems packed into the wall cores — a castle you could, if it came to that, eat your way through.



The Uto Turret and the twin keeps, seen together across the castle grounds. The keep on the right was rebuilt in 1960; the turret on the left has stood since Kiyomasa's own time — a contrast this book returns to in Chapter 2.

| The “warrior-repelling” stone walls

Kumamoto’s signature feature is its stonework, known as *musha-gaeshi* — “the wall that turns soldiers back.” The base rises at a gentle slope that looks climbable enough, but the curve steepens sharply toward the top, until the uppermost stretch runs almost sheer — a profile said to defeat even a ninja. Also known as the “fan-shaped slope,” it is decoration and defence solved in a single curve, and the fullest expression of Kiyomasa’s practical mind. Chapter 2 looks at how the shape actually works.

| 240 years under the Hosokawa

In 1632 the Kato family lost the domain, and **Hosokawa Tadatoshi** took possession of the castle in their place. For roughly **240 years**, until the Meiji Restoration, the Hosokawa governed Higo from Kumamoto — inheriting Kiyomasa’s castle, and his uncompromising idea of what a castle was for, more or less intact.

| The Satsuma Rebellion — proof of the impregnable, and the loss of the keep

In 1877, government forces found themselves besieged inside Kumamoto Castle by the rebel army of Saigo Takamori in the **Satsuma Rebellion**. The siege held for roughly fifty days of hard fighting.

Just before the fighting began, the keep and the main buildings of the inner bailey burned to the ground. The cause has never been settled — deliberate arson by the government garrison, to deny the rebels cover, is one account; an accidental fire is another. What is certain is that the castle itself held: the rebel army never broke in, and the siege became, in effect, a demonstration of exactly how sound Kiyomasa's stonework was. Saigo himself is said to have remarked afterwards that he had not been beaten by the government — he had been beaten by Kato Kiyomasa.



Kumamoto Castle photographed in 1874, seen from Bizenbori — three years before the keep in this picture was lost to fire in the Satsuma Rebellion. This is the building the siege of 1877 actually cost the castle.

A note — the tree that did not burn

A large ginkgo still stands in front of the keep, traditionally said to have been planted by Kiyomasa himself, along with a saying that ran with it: when the tree grows as tall as the keep, some great calamity will follow. When fire took the keep in 1877, the ginkgo alone survived unburned — and the castle's other name, Ginnan-jo, the "Ginkgo Castle," comes directly from that tree.



The ginkgo in front of the keep, said to have been planted by Kato Kiyomasa himself. It is the source of the castle's other name, Ginnan-jo.

| Rebuilt in concrete, and then struck by the 2016 earthquake

After the war, civic enthusiasm carried the project, and in 1960 the keep was rebuilt in **reinforced concrete**, closely following Edo-period drawings and early photographs. Eighty-three years after the fire of the Satsuma Rebellion, Kumamoto had its skyline back.

Then, in April 2016, the **Kumamoto Earthquake** — a foreshock and mainshock striking in close succession — hit the castle directly. Almost every roof tile on the main keep came down. All thirteen of the castle’s Important Cultural Property buildings were damaged, and roughly **thirty per cent of the stone walls** collapsed. At the Iida-maru Five-Story Turret, a single surviving column of stone held up the entire corner on its own — the so-called “**miracle stone pillar**,” widely photographed at the time as a symbol of hope for the recovery to come.



The “miracle stone pillar” at the Iida-maru turret base, wrapped in protective sheeting after the 2016 earthquake. A single column of stone held the corner up alone while everything around it had come down.

The keep itself was fully repaired by March 2021, with its interior reopened to the public that June. Restoring the whole castle was expected to take far longer — the city’s target for full completion was fiscal year 2052 — and the painstaking work of identifying and resetting each individual stone, one at a time, was still under way a decade later.

| And then, in 2026, the ground moved again

The repair work was roughly halfway along when, at 4:27pm on **28 July 2026**, an earthquake of **magnitude 7.1 and maximum seismic intensity 7** — the Reiwa 8 Kumamoto Earthquake — struck the region again. It had been only ten years since the last one.

A survey by the city found stone walls collapsed or destabilised at roughly **thirty separate locations**, including sections around both keeps, with interior finishes and roof tiles damaged at several points inside the keep as well. Around the twin keeps and near the Hikone Gate in particular, the damage carried a pointed irony: **new collapses appeared right next to sections that had only just been reset after the 2016 quake** — a stark reminder of exactly how much weight ten years of careful restoration had been carrying.

The paid areas of the castle were closed immediately after the quake while safety surveys were carried out. In 2016, it had taken roughly **five years** before the keep could reopen. This time, the castle reopened to the public after only **about two weeks**, on **13 August 2026** — a result widely credited to the seismic reinforcement carried out during the previous restoration.

A note — a castle repaired while being repaired again

Kumamoto Castle is, right now, in an unusually rare position: a castle still mid-repair from one earthquake when a second earthquake struck. The order and method of the first restoration appear to have shaped where the new damage fell, which means the castle is quietly building up something no finished monument can offer — a visible, ongoing record of **the craft of recovering from disaster itself**, changing a little more with every visit.

Reading the architecture — a castle that shows its scars

| The fan-shaped slope — a curve, not a wall

The *musha-gaeshi* stonework introduced in Chapter 1 is not simply a steep incline. Its defining feature is the **curve** itself — shallow at the base, sharply overhanging by the top. That curve lets the wall spread its own weight while still reaching an intimidating height, and it happens to look magnificent while doing it. Where Himeji Castle's effect rests on white plaster laid over the whole building, **the stonework itself is Kumamoto's headline feature.**



The stone walls at the southeast corner of Take-no-maru, seen across the moat. Look closely at where the curve steepens toward the top — the exact point that gives the wall its name.

| Uto Turret — the other keep

Standing at the northwest corner of the main bailey, the **Uto Turret** rises three storeys over five levels including its basement — sometimes called “the third keep,” and the largest surviving multi-storey turret in Japan. It escaped the fire of the Satsuma Rebellion and remains the **only multi-storey building at Kumamoto that still shows its original Edo-period form.** Damaged in the 2016 earthquake, it has been under dismantling and repair since 2022, with completion targeted for 2032. The contrast is the point: **the twin keeps are a reconstruction, the Uto Turret is the genuine article** — and standing between them is the clearest way to feel how much history this castle is actually carrying.



The Uto Turret and the long *tamon* turret running alongside it, seen in full from across the grounds. This is the building to study if you want to know what Kumamoto looked like before any of it needed rebuilding.

| Built for a siege that never ends

- **Over 120 wells** — dug throughout the grounds in case of prolonged siege; several can still be located today
- **Edible building materials** — dried gourd woven into tatami facing, taro stems packed into wall cores, according to tradition, so the castle itself could be eaten from if food ran out
- **Long walls and a dense scatter of turrets** — the main bailey is wrapped in turrets, gates and connecting walls laid out specifically to disorient anyone who broke through

| The unusual case of a castle that shows its own repair

Himeji and Hikone present themselves as finished buildings. Kumamoto, right now, cannot — and that turns out to be one of its most distinctive features. From the special viewing corridor described in Chapter 3, visitors can look directly onto stone walls still awaiting repair, scaffolding wrapped around turrets, and stones mid-way through being reset one at a time. A single castle is showing, simultaneously, **the construction techniques of the early Edo period, the damage of a Meiji-era civil war, and the earthquake recovery engineering of the Heisei and Reiwa eras** — three centuries of Japanese building craft, stacked on top of one another, on the same afternoon.



The special viewing corridor, raised above the stonework so visitors can look directly down onto the repair work in progress — sheeted stone awaiting resetting, scaffolding still standing where a turret is under repair. No other National Treasure or Important Cultural Property castle in Japan currently offers quite this view.

Everywhere else in this series, the architecture chapter describes a building as it stands. Here, it has to describe a building *in the middle of becoming itself again* — and that, more than any single feature, is what makes a second or third visit to Kumamoto worthwhile: the view from this corridor will not look the same next year.

Walking the castle

- ▶ Sakura-no-baba Josaien — enter here
- ▶ Ninomaru Plaza
- ▶ The special viewing corridor — raised about 6m above the ground
- ▶ The stonework of Iida-maru and Take-no-maru, seen from the corridor
- ▶ Tenshukaku Plaza, in front of the keep
- ▶ The main and secondary keeps — interior
- ▶ Kato Shrine — a hilltop view back over the castle

Plan	Time	What you see
Quick	About 1 hour	Viewing corridor plus the keep only
Standard	1.5-2 hours	Keep plus Sakura-no-baba Josaien for a taste of the castle town
Unhurried	About 3 hours	All of the above plus Kato Shrine and Ninomaru Plaza, taken slowly

Before you set off

Which areas are open changes as repair work progresses. Check the official website's recovery-status map before you visit, and expect it to be different from your last trip. The viewing corridor is an outdoor, elevated structure and may be closed to visitors in rain or high wind.

| Along the way



The main keep, seen rising above stonework and trees on the approach. From ground level the stonework and the keep read as one continuous shape — exactly the effect the fan-shaped slope was built to create.

| What not to miss

- **The fan-shaped stonework** — the curve reads differently from every angle; walk the corridor and the base wall both
- **The Uto Turret** — the original form the Satsuma Rebellion could not touch; among the largest surviving turrets in Japan
- **The “miracle stone pillar”**, at the Iida-maru turret base — a single column of stone that held a corner up alone, and a symbol of the 2016 recovery
- **Kato Shrine** — the classic head-on photograph of the keep
- **The ginkgo tree**, in front of the keep — Kiyomasa’s planting, and the source of the castle’s other name

Visiting

Admission

Open	9:00–17:00 (last admission 16:00); extended to 9:00–19:00 (last admission 18:00) in July and August
Admission	800 yen for adults and high school students; 300 yen for primary and middle school students
Access inside	Reopened 13 August 2026 after the Reiwa 8 earthquake. Which areas are open changes with the repair work — areas near the newest stone collapses are especially likely to carry extra restrictions
Official site	https://castle.kumamoto-guide.jp/

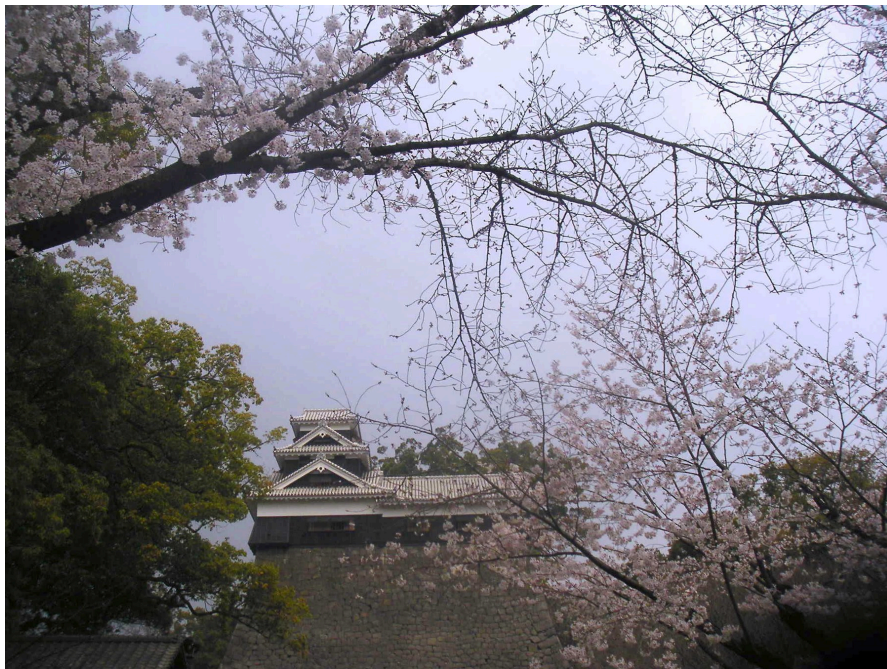
Fees, hours and open areas all change, more than usual right now. Please check the official website immediately before you travel.

Getting there

Nearest station	JR Kumamoto Station
By tram	About 17 minutes from Kumamoto Station to the “Kumamotojo/Shiyakusho-mae” stop, then about 7 minutes on foot
By bus	The “Shiromegurin” sightseeing loop bus from Kumamoto Station is a convenient alternative
By car	Paid car parks nearby, including Ninomaru and Sannomaru car parks

| The castle through the year

Spring	Cherry blossom around Ninomaru Plaza and along the Tsuboi River, set against the keep
Summer	Deep green setting off the stonework and the keep; extended opening hours in July and August
Autumn	Gold leaf on the ginkgo the castle takes its other name from; the texture of the stonework stands out
Winter	Clear air sharpens the curve of the fan-shaped stonework



The secondary keep seen through cherry blossom, beneath an overcast, slightly misted sky — spring at Kumamoto in one frame.

I Nearby — Kato Shrine

Dedicated to Kato Kiyomasa, **Kato Shrine** stands within the castle grounds and gives the single best head-on photograph of the keep anywhere on site. It is a working shrine as much as a viewpoint — worth the short climb even setting the camera aside.



The keep seen from within the grounds of Kato Shrine, backlit toward evening. This is the view the shrine is known for — and one of the few spots that lets you take in both keeps at once.



The white torii at the entrance to Kato Shrine, with the stonework visible off to one side.



Sakura-no-baba Josaen, the recreated castle-town street at the castle's entrance, with the keep just visible in the distance.

- **Sakura-no-baba Josaen** — a recreated castle town at the main entrance, lined with souvenir shops and restaurants serving Kumamoto specialities
- **Suizenji Jojuen** — a stroll garden elsewhere in Kumamoto City, laid out to evoke the fifty-three stations of the Tokaido road

Local food

- **Basashi (horse sashimi)** — Kumamoto's signature dish; the sweetness of the lean meat is usually served with a mild, dedicated soy sauce
- **Taipien** — a Kumamoto-born, Chinese-influenced noodle dish of glass noodles simmered with seafood and vegetables
- **Karashi renkon** — lotus root stuffed with hot mustard miso, with a history said to trace back to the Hosokawa household
- **Kumamoto ramen** — pork-bone broth finished with *mayu*, fragrant burnt-garlic oil

For a second visit

Almost nothing else in this series changes as fast as this castle. The stonework around the twin keeps, the state of the Uto Turret, which stretches of the viewing corridor are open — check again before you go, even if you have read this book before.

Credits and notes

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| About the information in this book

Admission fees, opening hours and access arrangements are subject to change, and are unusually unsettled following the earthquake of July 2026. Always check the official website before visiting. The information here reflects the time of writing, and no guarantee is made as to its accuracy or completeness.

| Principal sources

Kumamoto Castle official site — <https://castle.kumamoto-guide.jp/>

Kumamoto Castle recovery status — <https://castle.kumamoto-guide.jp/map/>

City of Kumamoto (Important Cultural Property designations, castle recovery plan)

Cultural Heritage Online (Agency for Cultural Affairs)

Japan Meteorological Agency, Reiwa 8 Kumamoto Earthquake portal

| Japan's Great Castles — Kumamoto Castle

Japan's Great Castles, Book One

Where the earlier series in this collection visited only the five castles whose keeps carry Japan's National Treasure designation, this series turns to castles across the country more broadly — National Treasure or not — each one for what makes it worth the journey on its own terms.